within minutes of the sinking of the *Charleston* and, eager to dispel lingering rumors that he was beholden to China for his electoral victory, confirmed the operational plans of Indo-Pacific Command issued on September 9, while approving further deployments of a second aircraft carrier, the *John C. Stennis*, and three more destroyers from Hawaii to the South China Sea, along with three nuclear attack submarines (SSNs), including the USS *Illinois*, from Submarine Group 7 in Guam to positions off the Strait of Malacca, the Paracel Islands, and Hainan Island. After making this decision, President Newsom went on national television to brief the nation, promising that he would protect American interests and never back down from America's role in the Pacific.

The Failure of Diplomacy

An urgent phone call between President Newsom and Chairman Xi that evening did little to stabilize the situation, and on the evening of September 10, Beijing time, a doctored video of the ramming of the *Bertholf* was spread in China that made it look like the Americans were to blame for the accident. Chinese internet censors allowed the clip to become a viral sensation, and stage-managed crowds soon thronged the gates of the American and Japanese embassies, shouting slogans denouncing the United States and Japan, throwing stones and trash onto the grounds, and demanding compensation from Washington and Tokyo.[39] Xi took to the airwaves to chastise the Americans, but also to try to rise above the fray, announcing that China would not further deepen the crisis. This tactic backfired, and crowds began moving toward Tiananmen Square, demanding that China push America out of Asia, while the internet lit up with criticism of Xi that questioned his mental state. Chinese overseas students and provocateurs under guidance from the CCP's United Front Work Department propaganda unit began coordinated protests in Sydney, Seoul, London, Paris, Toronto, and Vancouver, while small groups of Chinese students at US universities, including Harvard, Columbia, UC Berkeley, and UCLA, staged demonstrations that garnered widespread media coverage.[40]